

SplitSmart

Role **Lead UX/UI Designer** Timeline **4-week design sprint — May 2026** Type **Concept · Self-directed**

THE PROBLEM

When you are managing a Paris Trip group, a Home Bills group, and a Work Lunch group simultaneously, you are not just tracking debts. You are managing your own money. Every expense logged by a friend is a cost that lands on your personal budget — but expense apps only show the group's side of that equation.

COMPETITIVE AUDIT

I audited four apps — Splitwise, Tricount, Settle Up, and Venmo Groups — mapping tap depth to key actions and examining what financial information each surfaces at the home view.

Shared findings across all four apps:

- **Home screen shows groups or friends, not actions.** Balances were visible, but to settle or send a reminder you had to navigate into a group first. No app combined a balance with its primary action in the same view.
- **No personal budget layer.** Every app stopped at the group ledger. Your share of costs across all active groups was never aggregated or tracked against a personal cap.

Splitwise's own support forums surfaced this last gap repeatedly, with users requesting personal budget tracking — a feature the team acknowledged but deprioritised.

STRATEGY

Two layers. One app.

Shared expenses are still your expenses. A Paris Trip costs the group £700. But it costs *you* £233. That number belongs in your personal budget, not only in the group ledger.

Layer 1 — Shared expense management.

Split costs, track group balances, settle debts, send reminders.

Layer 2 — Personal budget intelligence.

A dedicated Budget screen that:

- Isolates your share of costs across all active groups
- Tracks your total spend against a monthly cap you set
- Forecasts where you will end the month at your current daily spend rate

These two layers are not separate features — they are the same financial reality seen from two angles: the group's ledger and your personal budget.

INFORMATION ARCHITECTURE

Before moving to high fidelity, I mapped the full app hierarchy: every screen, how they connect, and where key actions live. This made it possible to validate the two-layer structure — shared and personal — before committing to interface work, and to confirm that the Budget screen could sit as a peer to the Dashboard rather than buried inside it.

DESIGN DECISIONS

Dashboard — action next to position

The core decision was to place a balance and its settle action in the same view. When the next step is already visible, the user does not need to decide where to go — they simply act.

Budget screen — personal, not group

Rather than showing group totals, the Budget screen translates shared expenses into a personal financial picture: your share, your cap, your forecast.

Friends page — unresolved first

Relationships are ordered by what needs attention, not by recency. Unresolved balances surface at the top.

Groups page — remaining, not spent

The decision was to surface how much budget each group has remaining, not just how much it has spent. Remaining is actionable. Spent is history.

USABILITY TESTING

5 participants · 10 minutes each · unmoderated

Task	Result
Average time to identify balance	~4 seconds
Average taps to settle a balance	1–2 taps
Task completion rate	100%
Participants needing assistance	0 of 5
Understood budget status immediately	4 of 5
Expected to settle across all groups at once	3 of 5

All five participants completed primary tasks with no major navigation issues. Balance, settlement, and budget status were understood quickly across the board.

Key finding: Three participants expected to settle with a person across all groups at once, rather than group by group. This showed the settle flow conflicted with users’ natural mental model — they think in terms of *who* they owe, not *which group* the debt belongs to. This finding directly drove the redesign of the Settle Up screen.

Open question: One participant expected the settle action directly on the balance card, one tap earlier than the current flow allows. This wasn’t addressed in the redesign and remains a potential improvement.

"I expected to settle with one person across all groups at once."

"I can immediately tell what I actually spent."

"The budget makes shared expenses easier to understand."

"Feels simpler than other expense-splitting apps."

REDESIGN: SETTLE UP FLOW

Based on the testing findings, I redesigned the Settle Up screen to reflect how users naturally expected the feature to behave. Rather than settling one group at a time, the redesigned flow shows the minimum number of transfers required to clear all outstanding debts across all groups — consolidating by person, not by group.

GAPS AND TRADEOFFS

Gap 1 — No percentage-based or weighted splits

Every expense currently divides equally between members. Real groups rarely work that way: one person earns more, one person missed part of a trip, one person ordered less. Without support for custom splits by percentage, share count, or exact amount, SplitSmart forces a fairness assumption that doesn't hold in practice. This is the most functionally limiting constraint in the current design.

Gap 2 — No multi-currency support

The app assumes a single currency throughout. For international group trips — the core use case the Paris Trip example was designed around — this is a significant constraint that would need to be addressed before the app could serve its intended audience fully.

CONCLUSION

SplitSmart is built on the idea that users don't want to hold two mental models at once — the group's ledger and their own budget. The app brings those together in a single view, so shared expenses land where they actually belong: in your personal financial picture.
